Bombers

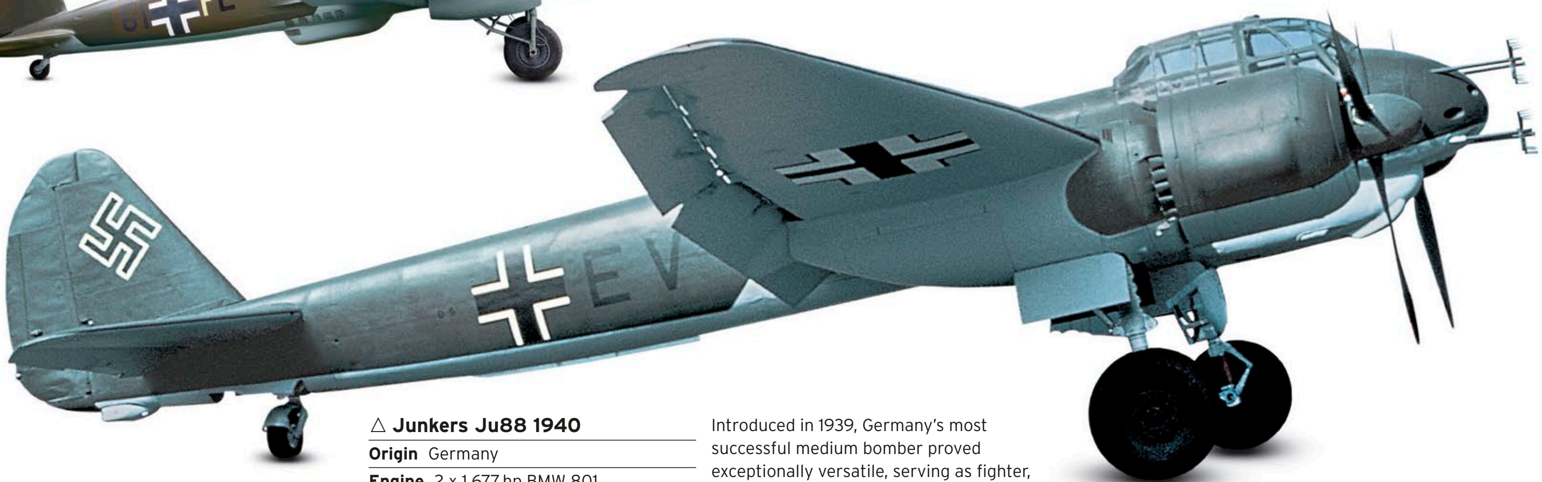
As soon as the threat of World War II was apparent, both sides knew that bomber aircraft could have a huge impact on the outcome of the war—by demoralizing the people, destroying the factories, disrupting army supplies, and attacking ground troops, tanks, and warships. Huge, multiengined aircraft were developed to carry ever-greater loads. Some bristled with gunners to counter fighter attack, while lighter, high-speed aircraft were built for more specific targeting.

△ Boeing B-17G Flying Fortress 1945
Origin USA
Engine 4 x 1,200 hp Wright R-1820-97 Cyclone turbocharged air-cooled 9-cylinder radial
Top speed 287 mph (462 km/h)

First flown in 1935, the B-17 was the USAAF's main precision daytime bomber in WWII. It was well defended and able to survive much damage, but it had only half the bomb capacity of an Avro Lancaster.

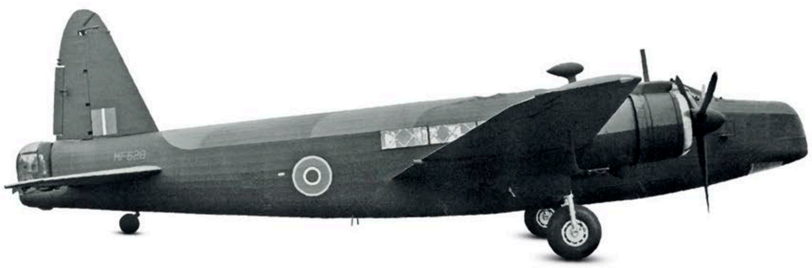
◁ Heinkel He111 1940
Origin Germany
Engine 2 x 1,340 hp Junkers Jumo 211 F-2 supercharged liquid-cooled inverted V12
Top speed 270 mph (434 km/h)

Disguised as a fast transport plane, when Germany was not allowed to build military aircraft, the He111 was an effective medium bomber. Introduced in 1935, it was progressively developed throughout WWII.



△ Junkers Ju88 1940
Origin Germany
Engine 2 x 1,677 hp BMW 801 supercharged air-cooled 14-cylinder radial
Top speed 342 mph (550 km/h)

Introduced in 1939, Germany's most successful medium bomber proved exceptionally versatile, serving as fighter, dive bomber, night-fighter, reconnaissance aircraft, trainer, and long-range escort. More than 15,000 were built.

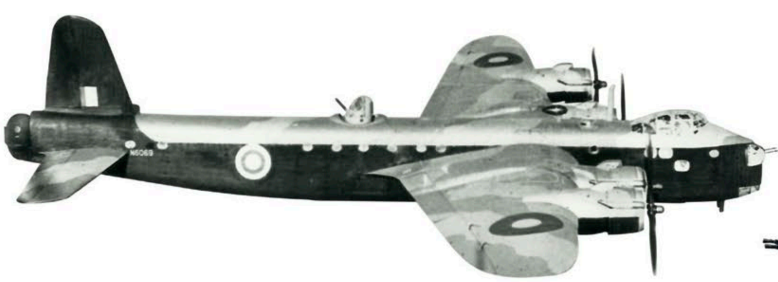


△ Vickers Wellington X 1940
Origin UK
Engine 2 x 1,050–1,735 hp Bristol Pegasus/Hercules supercharged air-cooled 14-cylinder radial
Top speed 270 mph (434 km/h)

Britain's most effective night bomber in the early years of WWII was introduced in 1938. It had a fabric-covered geodesic structure that could fly after severe damage. The Wellington was later adapted to other roles; 11,461 were built.

△ Fairey Albacore 1940
Origin UK
Engine 1,065–1,130 hp Bristol Taurus II/XII supercharged air-cooled 14-cylinder radial
Top speed 172 mph (277 km/h)

This three-seat reconnaissance aircraft and torpedo bomber was to be the Fleet Air Arm's successor to the Swordfish. Although it had a larger engine, enclosed cockpit, and heating, it would ultimately be retired first.



△ Shorts S29 Stirling 1941
Origin UK
Engine 4 x 1,500–1,635 hp Bristol Hercules supercharged air-cooled 14-cylinder radial
Top speed 270 mph (434 km/h)

The first four-engined bomber to enter RAF service, with a then-exceptional 14,000 lb (6,350 kg) payload, it was superseded by 1943 when its performance and range were outstripped by later designs.